

“Second Fool” opened his eyes and stared at the mud and thatch roof over his head. The quilt covering his body was a deep yellow color and had a musty smell. It was so old that its original color could no longer be distinguished.

Next to him lay his second brother, Han Zhu, who appeared to be in a deep slumber. Snore intermittently floated over as he slept.

Five feet from the bed was an earthen wall that had suffered from numerous cracks due to the passage of time. From the other side of the wall came the nagging voice of his mother and the occasional deep breathing of his father who was smoking his pipe.

Second Fool slowly closed his eyes, trying to force himself to sleep. He knew that if he didn’t go to sleep now, he wouldn’t be able to wake up early the next day. If he woke up late, he wouldn’t be able to go up to the mountains with his good friends to gather firewood.

Second Fool’s real name was Han Li. This elegant name was not given to him by his parents. When he was born, his parents had offered two pieces of cornbread to the village’s Elder Zhang in exchange for giving the baby Han Li a second name. [\[1\]](#)

When Uncle Zhang was young, he had attended school with the wealthy children in the city. As he was the only one in the village who knew how to read a few words, more than half of the children in the village were named by him.

Han Li was called “Second Fool” by those in the village. Despite his name, he wasn’t stupid looking or foolish. On the contrary, he was actually the smartest person in the village. But just like the other children, aside from when they were home, nobody called him by his official name “Han Li”. Instead, they called him by his pet name “Second Fool”.

The reason why he was nicknamed “Second Fool” was due to the fact that there was already someone named “Fool” in the village.

This type of nickname was nothing though. There were children in the village named “Doggy” and “Dumb Egg”. These names weren’t nearly as pleasant-sounding as “Second Fool”.

Because of this, Han Li felt some consolation even though he wasn’t very fond of his nickname.

Physically, Han Li was very ordinary. He was tan and matched the generic descriptions of a child born in a farming village. Deep in his heart however, he had matured faster than others of the same age. Ever since he was young, he had yearned that one day, he would be able to leave his small village and explore the fertile lands of the outside world that Uncle Zhang had always talked about.

Han Li had never dared to speak of his dreams to anyone else in the village because they would be deeply shocked. After all, leaving this place was a notion that even adults didn’t

easily think about, let alone a small child. Children around his age only knew how to chase chickens and pet dogs. They had never entertained the strange notion of leaving the village.

Han Li's family had a total of seven members, including two older brothers, one older sister and one younger sister. He was the fourth eldest in his family and turned ten this year. Together, they lived a hard yet honest lifestyle. Very rarely did they get to eat meat and fish, but the entire family was content with living with the meager resources they had.

At this moment, Han Li was hovering between the state of sleep and consciousness. As he slowly drifted to sleep, only one thought was on his mind. While in the mountains, he had to pick more red berries for his younger sister whom he doted on the most!

The next morning, at noon, Han Li was shielding himself from the scorching sun overhead in the shade casted by the pile of lumber on his back. Wrapped around his chest was a pouch filled to the brim with red berries that bounced with each step as he walked home. He had no idea that at this moment, there was a guest in his home, a guest that that would change his destiny forever.

This guest was actually someone who had very close blood ties with Han Li. It was his Third Uncle!

It was rumored that his Third Uncle was the shopkeeper of a restaurant in the nearby city. According to his parents, Third Uncle was the most capable within their family. After a few hundred years, the Han family had finally produced someone like his Third Uncle, a figure with status and respect that was unrivaled within the family.

When Han Li was young, he had only met his Third Uncle a few times. Han Li's older brother became a blacksmith's apprentice in the city thanks to Third Uncle's introduction. Every so often, this Third Uncle would even gift some food to his parents to bring home and eat. Because he had looked after Han Li's family with great consideration, Han Li had a very good impression of him. Even though his parents never said anything, he knew that in their hearts, they were very grateful.

Han Li's eldest brother was the family's pride and joy. As an apprentice of a blacksmith, he was able to bring home 30 copper coins every month, minus living expenses. And when he finally graduated from his apprenticeship, he would earn even more money!

Every time his parents talked about their eldest son, their spirits would soar with pride. Although Han Li was young, he was tremendously envious. The best work he could find was to be the apprentice of a craft master and rely on the crafts he made to earn money.

So when Han Li saw the brand new satin robes and the round face that belonged to his Third Uncle, Han Li was overjoyed.

Setting down the firewood in a corner outside of the house, he went to the front of the house to greet his Third Uncle. "Third Uncle, Han Li greets you." After doing so, he obediently stood to the side and listened to his Third Uncle chat with his parents.

Third Uncle beamed at Han Li as he opened his mouth, praising his nephew. "What a sensible child!" After complimenting Han Li, he turned his attention back to Han Li's parents and explained the reason for his visit.

Although Han Li wasn't able to fully understand the words his Third Uncle was saying as he was too young, he still roughly understood what was said.

It turned out his Third Uncle's restaurant had the backing of the Seven Mysteries Sect. This sect was divided into the inner and outer divisions. Not too long ago, Third Uncle had been officially recognized as an outer disciple. That meant that he could bring a child between the ages of 7 and 12 to take the Inner Disciple Examinations.

Once every 5 years, the Seven Mysteries Sect would formally issue invitations for youngsters to take the test to become Inner Disciples. The test would officially begin the following month. Third Uncle was a smart and astute man who was childless, so he naturally thought of Han Li who met the age requirement.

The moment the usually docile Father Han heard the words "Jiang Hu" and "Sect", along with many other phrases he had never heard before, he felt very hesitant. Bringing his smoking pipe to his lips and giving it a puff, he sat down without saying a word. [\[2\]](#)

According to Third Uncle, the Seven Mysteries Sect could be considered one of the best sects within several hundred miles.

If one were to become an Inner Disciple, not only would one be able to practice martial arts for free, one would also receive a monthly allowance and have his needs taken care of. Not only that, those who didn't pass the Inner Disciple Examinations could still enter the sect's outer division and become an outer disciple like Third Uncle. They would still have the opportunity to help the Seven Mysteries Sect handle its external affairs.

Upon hearing the possibility that his son could receive a monthly allowance and even become as successful as his Third Uncle, Han Li's father finally decided to give his approval.

After getting the approval from Han Li's father, Third Uncle felt elated. Leaving behind two silver coins, he said that he would return in a month to escort Han Li to the testing area. During this period of time, Han Li's father had to ensure that Han Li was clothed and well fed to improve his constitution so that it would be easier for him to pass the test. After giving these instructions, Third Uncle bid farewell to Han Li and his father, patted Han Li on his head and left for the city.

While Han Li didn't fully comprehend his Third Uncle's words, he could understand that he would be able to earn money in the big city. It seemed that his dream from before was

finally going to come true, making him so excited that he could not sleep for the first few nights.

After one month had passed, Third Uncle returned to the village, wanting to escort Han Li to the testing site. Before he left, Han Li's father repeatedly instructed Han Li on the ways of proper behavior.

One must be honest, have the capacity to endure, and avoid unnecessary conflicts with others. Meanwhile, Han Li's mother urged him to take care of his health and to eat and sleep well.

On the carriage, Han Li had to bite down on his lips to prevent himself from crying, as he watched his parents gradually disappear from sight.

Although he had always been more mature than other children of the same age, he was still just a ten year-old child. This was the first time he had left home, so he naturally felt depressed. A homesickness developed in his heart, and he was determined to rush home after he struck rich, never to be separated from his parents again.

Han Li would never have thought that from this moment on, money would lose any meaning to him. He was unexpectedly going to walk a path different from ordinary mortals. Instead, he was going to walk down his own path towards immortality!

Green Ox City was said to be a small city, but it was actually just a large village called Green Ox Village. Only those who lived in the mountainous region and the natives with no knowledge of the outside world called the village Green Ox City. The only reason Han Li knew about this was because he had been informed by his Uncle Zhang, who had been working as a gatekeeper for more than ten years.

Green Ox Village wasn't very large. It only had one main road, known as Green Ox Street, which spanned from the eastern to the western borders of the village. There was also only one tavern in village, located on its western border. For any traveling merchant that didn't want to sleep outdoors, this tavern was the only option.

There was only one road for carriages in the western part of Green Ox Village. It ran from the gates of the village and the Green Ox Tavern all the way to the Spring Fragrance Restaurant, the only other place anyone would visit besides the tavern.

Spring Fragrance Restaurant wasn't big by any means and was actually quite old-fashioned. However, this establishment had a certain charm that was appealing to many travelers. Every day at noon, there would always be a crowd of people, making the place constantly swamped.

A bearded man with a round face emerged from a carriage along with a dark skinned, rotund little boy who looked to be around ten years old, and they both walked into the restaurant with a swagger. All of the regular customers knew who this man was. He was the manager of this restaurant, "Fatty Han." The boy, however, was not someone they were familiar with.

"Elder Han, this tanned little boy resembles you a lot. Could it be a child from a prostitute you spent the night with?" someone joked.

The moment the joke was uttered, the entire restaurant roared with laughter.

"Peh! This is the son of my blood brother, my own nephew! Of course he'll look like me," Fatty Han said proudly instead of being angered.

This duo had traveled for three whole days without rest before arriving at the village. They were Han Li and his Third Uncle, who was known as "Fatty Han" by the village people.

Fatty Han greeted a few regulars before bringing Han Li to the back of the restaurant, and entered a remote courtyard.

"Xiao Li, you should rest here for a while. When the time comes for the Inner Disciple Examinations, I'll call you. For now, I must leave in order to attend to a few regulars." Fatty Han pointed at a side room in the courtyard and kindly motioned for Han Li to enter it. [\[1\]](#)

After saying that, Han Li's Third Uncle turned around and hurried back inside the restaurant to tend to his customers.

As he reached the door, he felt a sudden unease in his heart and reminded Han Li, "Don't run about. You might get lost in the village if you wander around. So it's best if you don't leave this courtyard."

"En!"

Hearing Han Li's honest response, he nodded in relief and walked out the door.

After his Third Uncle left the courtyard, Han Li suddenly felt exhausted. The moment his head landed on his pillow, he fell into a deep sleep and began snoring, surprisingly without the fear of a normal kid staying alone in unfamiliar surroundings.

When the night came, a servant came by with some food. Although it wasn't a lavish meal, it was still delicious. After Han Li ate the food, the servant was clearing away the remaining dishes when his Third Uncle leisurely walked in.

"How was it? Was the meal suitable to your taste? Do you miss your home?"

"Yes, I miss home..." Han Li replied in his childish voice.

Third Uncle seemed satisfied with Han Li's response. He began to talk to him about his daily life and bragged about many of his experiences. Gradually, Han Li became less shy and started to laugh and talk with his Third Uncle.

In this manner, two days passed by quickly.

On the third day, after Han Li finished his dinner, he was waiting for his uncle's stories of Jiang Hu when a carriage stopped in front of the restaurant door. [\[2\]](#)

This carriage was painted a shiny black color and even the horse was a rarely seen golden steed. But what attracted the most attention was that on the frame of the carriage was the word "Mystery" written in silver characters in the middle of a red triangle emblazing a black banner. The image on the banner also emitted an unfathomable air.

Seeing this banner, every martial arts expert in the area knew that this carriage belonged to one of the two local overlords in the area, the Seven Mysteries Sect. It seemed that an esteemed guest had arrived in Green Ox Village.

The Seven Mysteries Sect was previously known as the Seven Supreme Sect, and the sect was established two hundred years ago by an extremely famous martial master named "Sovereign Seven Supreme". Having once swept across and dominated the Jing Province and the nearby Shu Province for a few decades, the Sovereign Seven Supreme was resoundingly famous. But after he was afflicted with illness, the power of the Seven Mysteries Sect took a devastating hit and its influence dropped drastically. In the end, the Seven Mysteries Sect was forced out of the main city of the Jing Province by the combined efforts of its rival sects.

Thus, a hundred years ago, the sect was forced to relocate to an extremely remote area called the Celestial Rainbow Mountain. From then on, they rebuilt their roots in that third rate region and became a local powerhouse.

As the old saying goes: "a starved camel is still bigger than a horse". The Seven Mysteries Sect had once been a major sect, so it still possessed substantial potential. Once it arrived at Celestial Rainbow Mountain, it immediately gained control over around a dozen towns and villages, including Green Ox Village, and it had around 4,000 disciples, making it one of the two undisputed supreme powers in the area.

Locally, the only other power that could rival the Seven Mysteries Sect was the Feral Wolf Gang.

The Feral Wolf Gang was originally a gang of horse-mounted bandits from the Jing Province that had no qualms about burning, killing, looting and pillaging. After a while, an army dispatched by the imperial court encircled and fiercely suppressed the bandits. Some of the bandits accepted the amnesty granted to them by the imperial court while the remaining bandits reformed themselves into the Feral Wolf Gang. The Feral Wolf Gang was exceedingly cruel and bloodthirsty, retaining their former characteristics of having no qualms about committing atrocities. Thus, whenever they clashed, the Seven Mysteries Sect was always at a disadvantage.

Even though the Feral Wolf Gang controlled more villages than the Seven Mysteries Sect, the gang didn't know how to manage the villages effectively to run businesses and generate income. In comparison, the wealth of the villages controlled by the Seven Mysteries Sect vastly outstripped the villages under Feral Wolf Gang's control. Jealous of the Seven Mysteries Sect's prosperity, the Feral Wolf Gang made plans to take over the Sect's territory, resulting in the longstanding conflict between the two major powers. The conflict gave the current Sect Leader of the Seven Mysteries Sect endless headaches. Because of the Feral Wolf Gang, the Seven Mysteries Sect has been accepting an increasing number of disciples in recent years.

After the carriage stopped, a skinny forty year-old man jumped down. His movements were extremely nimble, indicating that he was a powerful expert. He seemed to be very familiar with Fatty Han's restaurant and walked pompously towards the room Han Li was residing in.

Upon seeing the forty year-old man, Fatty Han immediately greeted him respectfully.

"Protector Wang, why has an esteemed person such as yourself personally made the trip?"

"Humph!" Protector Wang coldly snorted.

"The roads here haven't been peaceful lately. Because of this, there's a need to strengthen the defenses. Thus, the elders ordered that I personally come. Don't speak any more rubbish. Is this the child you wanted to nominate?"

“Yes, yes, this is my nephew. I hope that Protector Wang will take care of him.”

Looking at the impatient look on Protector Wang face, Third Uncle immediately retrieved a heavy-looking pouch and secretly passed it over to Protector Wang.

After he assessed the weight of the pouch, Protector Wang’s impatient demeanor visibly relaxed.

“Fatty Han, you truly know how to conduct yourself! On the way back, I will make sure that all of your nephew’s needs are well cared for. Anyways, it is getting pretty late now. We had best hurry on our way.”